

HANQI WANG

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Education

Ph.D. in Economics , University of British Columbia	2021 – May 2027 (expected)
M.A. in Economics , University of British Columbia	2021
B.M.O.S. (Honors) , Accounting and Economics, Western University	2020

Fields

Primary Econometric Theory
Secondary Applied Econometrics; Microeconomic Theory

Job Market Paper

Estimating a Rational Inattention Discrete Choice Model: A Semiparametric Approach

Abstract. People's choices depend on both the payoffs of the available options and what they learn about those payoffs before deciding. This paper develops methods that use aggregate choice data to distinguish unobserved payoff heterogeneity from costly information acquisition in a rational inattention discrete choice model. Under Shannon information costs, I establish conditions for semiparametric point identification using exogenous payoff and information-cost shifters, leaving the taste shock distribution and the information-cost function nonparametric. With two alternatives, I show that the probability of choosing one option, as a function of an exogenous payoff shifter, can be interpreted as a cumulative distribution function whose moments identify the payoff coefficients and the information-cost function. A standard deconvolution argument then identifies the taste shock distribution. I extend identification to multiple alternatives. I then propose an estimator based on observed market shares and establish its consistency. Because binding parameter constraints can lead to nonnormal limiting distributions, I construct confidence regions by test inversion without requiring asymptotic normality of the estimator. An application to Amazon Mechanical Turk illustrates the implications of information costs for workers' responses to wages.

References

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Fellowships and Awards

Four Year Doctoral Fellowship (4YF), University of British Columbia	2022 – 2026
Board of Directors' Gold Medal, King's University College at Western University	2020
Highest final-year average in the B.M.O.S. Honors program	
Dean's Honor List, Western University	2016 – 2019

Work in Progress

Directed Search with Rational Inattention

Abstract. This paper develops a directed search model of matching between heterogeneous workers and firms, in which workers must acquire costly information about wages before deciding where to apply. Workers observe firm types but not realized wages and acquire information at a Shannon entropy cost that can vary across worker types. I define a rationally inattentive search equilibrium in which application choices determine congestion across submarkets, while congestion shapes job-finding probabilities and the returns to information. I first establish equilibrium existence when the wage distribution has finite support and job-finding probabilities depend continuously on workers' application probabilities. The existence proof allows workers to have multiple optimal information-acquisition strategies. It exploits the fact that linear-fractional maps send convex sets to convex sets, together with workers' optimality conditions, to apply Kakutani's fixed-point theorem. I then establish conditions for identifying worker-type-specific information costs using twin job types with identical amenity values but different wages. Given known matching technology and equal job-finding probabilities for the twins, identification uses conditional and ex-ante choice shares to recover information costs. The identifying relationship links the twins' difference in expected wage income to the difference between their conditional and ex-ante log choice odds. Together, these results provide an equilibrium foundation and an empirical strategy for measuring attention costs in job search.

Conference and Seminar Presentations

Econometric Society North American Summer Meeting, Emory University	June 2026
Canadian Economics Association Annual Conference, Simon Fraser University	May 2026

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Vancouver School of Economics, UBC

ECON 325	Introduction to Econometrics I	Summer 2026
ECON 425	Advanced Econometrics	Fall 2022, Spring 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026
ECON 327	Introduction to Empirical Methods	Fall 2023
ECON 301	Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis I	Spring 2023
ECON 102	Principles of Macroeconomics	Spring 2021
ECON 334	Economic History of Modern Europe	Fall 2020

Research Experience

Research Assistant to Professor Kyungchul Song, UBC	Sept 2024 – May 2025
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Professional Service

Referee for <i>Journal of Econometric Methods</i>	2026
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Skills and Languages

Programming	Julia (structural estimation), Python, R, Stata, SQL
Languages	English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (native)
Citizenship	People's Republic of China